

take the opportunity to evacuate the city before the Union encirclement was complete.

Although these failures were disheartening, Grant realized that if he had not allowed his men to try a direct assault against Vicksburg, they might not have accepted the drudgery of the ensuing siege. He and his bluecoats, now reinforced to 70,000 strong, settled into a five-week siege. For their opponents, trapped inside Vicksburg's defenses, the constant artillery barrage strained their nerves, and the scarcity of food tested their physical stamina.

Pemberton's soldiers went on half and then quarter-rations as the balmy weeks of June progressed. Skinned rats and mulemeat became food. Civilians abandoned their homes and sought safety in dugouts excavated from the hillsides.

Despite these harsh conditions, Vicksburg's denizens remained defiant, confident that Joseph E. Johnston's relief army would soon lift the siege and attack Grant from the rear. "We may look at any hour for his approach," wrote the editor of the Vicksburg newspaper, now printed on the back of old wallpaper. "Hold out a few days longer, and our lines will be opened, the enemy driven away, the siege raised." Johnston's army, hovering to the east of the city but blocked by seven Federal divisions under Sherman, had grown to 30,000 men in a matter of weeks, but many were inexperienced troops or untested conscripts. Worse, their commander was hesitant to attack the numerically superior Yankees.